

LAPTOPS

Laptops let you take your work home, your home to work and your play to the road—and today’s laptops do this better than ever. Now the name of the game is immense functionality in terms of integrated peripherals and connectivity, with no compromise on processing power.

One for the road

The most important question to ask when buying a laptop is what application is it going to be used for? This will help give you the parameters to judge it by. For example, a laptop replete with features and processing power but slightly heavy and on the larger side, would suit users who plan to carry it between places but the bulk of the usage would be at a desktop and in transit. On the other hand, those who want portability over all else, should look for the smallest, thinnest and lightest device they can find, even at the cost of a slight loss on the processing power and perhaps on the functionality front too.

This gives us a few characteristics that need to be evaluated before buying a laptop. Firstly, the processor is very important since it gives you the power to run all your applications. Go for one that complements your applications and needs. The same applies for the amount of RAM and the hard disk capacity. Next, evaluate the number of connectivity options you need. If you make many presentations, you need video outputs for displaying on a projector, integrated Ethernet and modem for connectivity. In newer laptops, you can even get features such as 802.11b WiFi compliance or Blue-

Nominees		
Name	Contacts	Comments
ACi Impression	Allied Computer International (Asia) Pvt Ltd, Ph: 022-26366800	This laptop features a 1.5 GHz 4 Mobile processor, 256 MB memory and even a DVD-RW drive, ideal for the power-hungry professional.
Zenith Portable Desktop	Zenith Computers Ltd, Ph: 022-28377300	Sporting a 1.6 GHz Pentium 4 processor and 128 MB of DDR memory, this laptop is a suitable desktop replacement and offers many configurability and peripheral

tooth connectivity. Also keep an eye out for integrated features such as a CD-RW drive or a DVD-ROM drive.

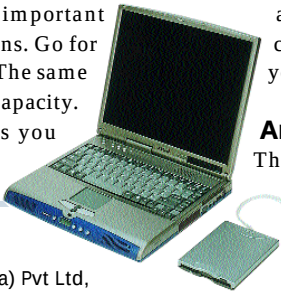
If portability is your main requirement, go for the smallest, lightest laptop you can find, though you might have to compromise on processing power and integrated functionality. Finally, consider the battery life—since the device is primarily meant for portability, search for a laptop that specifies a standby time of at least 4 hours. Anything less would require you to carry around a power supply, charger and stay on a constant lookout for power outlets where you can charge it from.

And the award goes to...

The laptop that screamed with sheer performance was the ACi Emerald. Boasting a 2 GHz Pentium 4 processor, 128 MB DDR RAM and a 20 GB hard disk, this laptop has the power to keep you working smoothly while on the road. In terms of connectivity, it featured four USB ports, a FireWire port and integrated Ethernet and modem. With adequate power and plenty of connectivity options, this device blurs the difference between a desktop and a laptop.



ACi Emerald
Allied Computer International (Asia) Pvt Ltd,
Ph: 022-26366800



The verdict: Built around a 2 GHz Pentium 4 mobile processor with DDR memory, this computer is a very viable desktop replacement, even for the most graphically intensive tasks

ANTI-VIRUS

Norton AntiVirus 2003

One of the most trusted names in the industry, Norton’s newest version strives to give you higher security. Norton AntiVirus 2003 incorporates a new scanning engine; it even scans your instant messenger for any harmful programs that might sneak in through file transfers during chat conversations. Norton AntiVirus 2003’s new, smoother engine is both light on the system and fast at scanning, making it less tedious to scan large volumes or entire hard disks.

The software protects your computer against SMTP-based worms, Trojans, etc. It is extremely user-friendly, with numerous wizards for configuring and setting the various parameters essen-

tial for safety. It packs the trademark compulsory scheduling agent and auto-update feature.

With a wide array of features, easy interface and the ability to track even your instant messenger, Norton AntiVirus 2003 wins top honours for protecting your systems.



Norton AntiVirus 2003



Symantec, Ph: 022-26570651
The verdict: Norton AntiVirus 2003 boasts of a new scanning engine that is significantly lighter on the system, newer and up-to-date definitions and the ability to restore files damaged due to